

Treasure Pyramid

The Game Itself

Players: 2–4

Play time: 12–18 minutes

Goal: Be the first explorer to reach the Sun Chamber and claim the golden idol.

Components

- 1 printed board (complex path version): Treasure Pyramid – Complex Path Sketch (v2)
- 1 pawn per player
- A small deck of trivia/fact cards (24 ready-to-print cards: PDF)
- 1 Scarab Block token per player (any coin/button works)

Core Turn Loop

1. Another player reads you a trivia card (10-second limit).
2. You move 4 spaces if correct, 2 if wrong/skip.
3. If you land on a special space, resolve it immediately.
4. Optionally place your Scarab Block on one square you passed through this turn (details under Conflict).
5. Next player.

Path Sketch

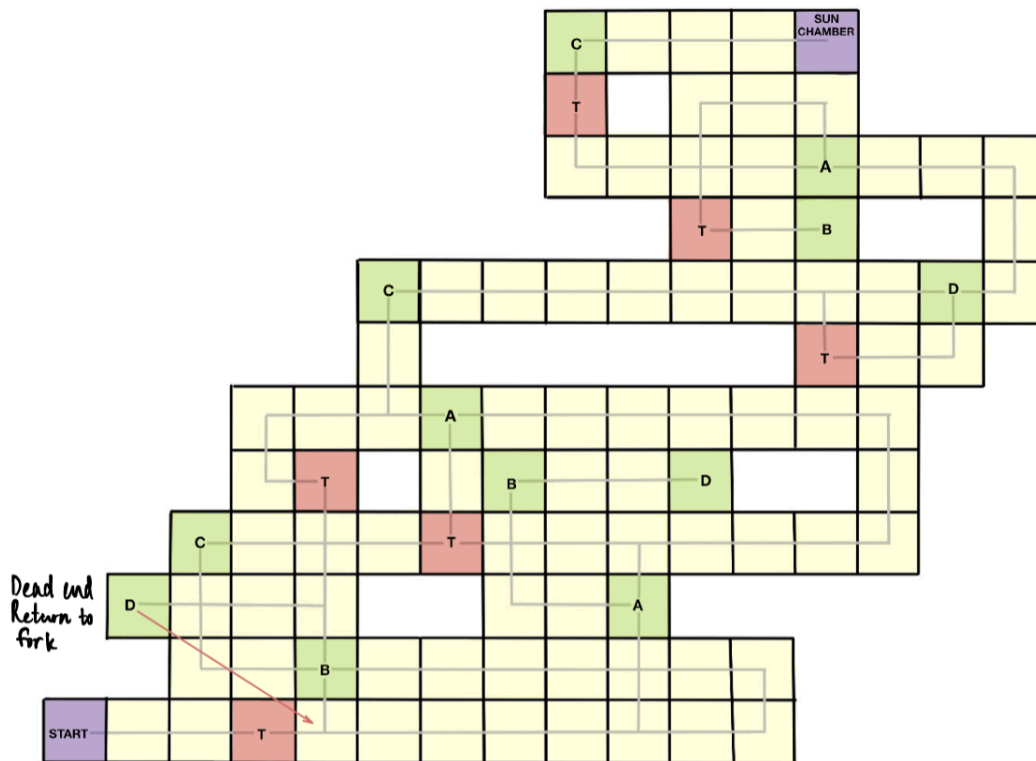
The board is a large pyramid-style maze with branching corridors, interior loops, and a marked dead end that sends you back to the last fork.

Special tiles on the map

- **T** = Trap (rose): skip your next turn.
- **A / B / C / D** = Secret Passage glyphs (green): teleport forward to the next tile with the same letter (toward the Sun Chamber).
If you are already on the last glyph of that letter, move +2 instead.

Start & End

- **START**: bottom-left entrance.
- **END (Sun Chamber)**: top-right. Overshoot is allowed—if your move would pass the chamber, you still win.



Theme / Objective / Narrative

Ancient corridors twist beneath the dunes. As alarms echo and sand begins to pour, explorers dash through galleries, avoid traps, and use glyph-portals to leap ahead. The first to reach the Sun Chamber before it seals forever takes the idol, and the glory.

Movement Mechanic & End Condition

- **Movement via Trivia:** On your turn, another player reads you a Trivia Card. You have **10 seconds** to answer.
 - **Correct:** Move 4 spaces.
 - **Incorrect / No answer:** Move 2 spaces.
- **Choosing a Route at Forks:** When you move onto a fork, you may choose which branch to continue along.
- **Resolving Landed Tile:** If you land on T or a glyph, resolve it immediately.
- **Passing Through vs Landing:** Specials only trigger when you land on them, not when you pass over them.
- **End Condition:** Overshoot allowed. If your movement would carry you beyond the Sun Chamber, you still win immediately. (You dove through the closing door!)

Conflict Rules

- **Corridor Block (Scarab):** After you finish moving, you may place your Scarab on one square you passed this turn.
 - The square is blocked until the start of your next turn; no pawn may enter or pass through it.
 - You cannot place a block on START or the Sun Chamber.
 - Multiple blocks on the same square: Allowed; the square remains blocked as long as any active block is present.
 - Movement vs blocks: If your movement (or teleport) would cross a blocked square, stop on the last legal square before it; excess movement is lost.
- **Occupancy:** Multiple pawns may share a square (no bumping).

Example (teleport + block): You land on B; the next B ahead is on a square that's currently blocked. Instead of arriving there, you stop on the previous unblocked square just before that B. Your teleport is done.

Iteration Log (from quick playtests)

Method: Three short tabletop playtests (2–3 players each) on the complex board (v2).

1. Deck too easy → runaway leaders.

- *Before:* Avg. game time ≈ 7 min, median 10 turns; many 4-step moves.
- *Change:* Rebalanced to ≈50% medium/hard questions.
- *After:* Avg. game time ≈ 12 min, median 16 turns; closer races and more route decisions.

2. Block spam → soft locks.

- *Before:* Blocks could be placed anywhere and lingered; loops stalled.
- *Change:* May only block a square you passed this turn; expires at start of your next turn; no blocks on START/Sun Chamber.
- *Result:* Keeps tactical denial without stalemates.

3. Teleport confusion.

- *Before:* Players tried backward or chain teleports.
- *Change:* Forward-only to the next matching letter; last glyph = +2.
- *Result:* Faster turns, fewer disputes.

4. Dead end too punishing.

- *Change:* Dead end returns you to the last fork (not START).
- *Result:* Still a setback, not a game-killer.

5. Late-game too linear.

- *Change:* Added D-glyphs and a late Trap near the top tiers.
- *Result:* Real choices and risk at the finish.

Theoretical Analysis

Is this a “game”? (Two definitions)

McGonigal: A game features a goal, rules, a feedback system, and voluntary participation.

- **Goal:** Reach the Sun Chamber first.
- **Rules:** Movement by trivia (4/2), forward-only glyph teleports, traps, corridor blocking, overshoot wins.
- **Feedback:** Pawn positions and visible blocks show progress and obstacles at a glance.
- **Voluntary:** Players opt in and can choose difficulty themes for the deck.
Therefore, *Treasure Pyramid* clearly satisfies McGonigal's four elements.

Crawford: A game involves interaction, conflict, and safety.

- **Interaction & conflict:** Scarab blocking, route selection at forks, and racing to glyphs directly affect opponents.
- **Safety:** Setbacks are purely within the play system—no real-world harm.
Thus, it meets Crawford's criteria as well.

Types of Fun (LeBlanc)

- **Challenge:** Time-limited questions, choosing efficient routes, and timing blocks create meaningful, learnable difficulty.
- **Discovery / Narrative:** Exploring branches, hitting hidden glyph chains, and "just-in-time" escapes produce little story beats.
- **Fellowship:** Table talk around reading questions, pleading at forks, and clever block placements builds social fun.

Bartle Player Type(s)

- **Achievers** will optimize accuracy (study/guess tactics), count spaces, and plan routes to thread glyphs while avoiding traps.
- **Explorers** will enjoy testing branches, learning where glyphs lead, and discovering the safer lines through the maze.

